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Shafali Verma | 21 |

Innings: 2; Runs: 97; Average: 48.5

Call her destiny's child. Left out of the initial World Cup squad, Shafali was training at the SRNCC Academy in Sultanpur, Haryana, when fate intervened. A freak ankle and knee injury to opener Pratika Rawal during the league match against Bangladesh opened the door for her return. Stepping into the squad only in the semifinals would unnerve most players—but not Shafali, the fearless hitter who once cut her hair short to pass as a boy just so she could play cricket. Having already led Indian women to their maiden ICC title—the 2023 Under-19 T20 World Cup—she brought the same composure and fire to the final, producing her career-best ODI score of 87 and best bowling figures of 2–36. In doing so, she became the youngest player ever—across men's and women's cricket—to be named Player of the Match in a World Cup final or semifinal.

learn a lot," she said earlier this year. "Knowing that a franchise has picked you gives you a lot of confidence, as does doing well against quality players and in different conditions."

THE MARCH FORWARD

From having a minimal match calendar, there's a gradual upswing in women's cricket. In 2023, the ICC introduced the under-19 T20 World Cup (India have won both editions); 2026 will see the tenth edition of the Women's T20 World Cup before which there will be the new season of WPL from February-March; 2027 will mark the inaugural Champions Trophy, a competition in the T20 format. What is needed are more Test matches—the longest format of the game is a test of true grit and skill. ICC doesn't even have a team or players' rankings for women in Tests.

But change is in the air. The last time India hosted the World Cup in 2013, the matches ran to empty stadiums. But the packed arenas in Visakhapatnam and Navi Mumbai, and the record TV and streaming viewing for the India matches show how far women's cricket has come. "For women's cricket to go upwards," Jhulan tells INDIA TODAY, "we needed a big *dhamaka* like the 1983 World Cup. It will help budding cricketers find role models and take up the game professionally."

To retain the momentum of this win, Shubhangi suggests, state associations must focus on cricket at the grassroots and also prioritise fitness among players. Right now, that happens only if you play for the national team. Nooshin bats for an increase in domestic match fees. Currently, it is Rs 20,000 for ODIs and Rs 10,000 for T20. An increase in earnings will mean less chances of dropouts, since many young girls opt for a career with guaranteed earnings once they graduate.



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— JHULAN GOSWAMI, *Ace bowler*

What this historic win reiterates is that a nation progresses rapidly only when its women are as empowered as its men in every field. On November 2, India's women in blue took a giant leap in that direction by overcoming self-doubt and smashing the glass ceiling in sports. ■